

How does partisan attachment influence affective polarization?*

Conceptualization, measurement, and scope conditions in 25 European democracies

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DRAFT: Work in progress. Please do not cite or circulate without the author's permission. Current status: framing and roadmap notes.

1 Introduction

- Affective polarization is a phenomenon that has received enormous prominence among political science since Iyengar, Sood, and Lelkes ([2012](#)) seminal paper
- This surge has stipulated various theoretical, conceptual and measurement debates
- Traditionally originating in the American two-party context, comparative scholars increasingly focussed on transferring insights and approaches to multiparty systems, whose party system structures complicates both theorizing and empirically investigating AP
- Basic AP in 2012:
 - introduces distinction between ideological and affective polarization
 - ingroup love and outgroup hate in partisan / political contexts

*Space for acknowledgements. Wordcount: .

- US: two parties -> partisan ingroup / outgroup distinction easy
- ambiguities:
 - * polarization as *state* (levels of AP) or *process* (trends of AP)?
 - * normative implications: early research posited negative implications for democracy, recent studies question this simple association
- Refinements since:
 - differentiating the targets of AP: horizontal or social AP (among citizens) vs vertical or political AP (toward parties (PAP) or party leaders (LAP))
 - differentiating attitudinal/expressive AP (e.g. thermoscores) and behavioral AP (e.g. Trust Games)
 - conceptual and measurement closely related:
 - * how to define ingroup(s), one or multiple?
 - how to *code* ingroup(s)? Identity/attachement vs (rep.) vote choice?
 - * how to define outgroup(s), least liked or average across outgroups?
 - * inclusion or exclusion of non-partisans
 - * in comparative literature, three main approaches have mostly been applied to measure AP with thermometer ratings:
 - Reiljan (2020)'s AP index, which assigns an ingroup and averages across all outgroups, the difference constituting the AP quantity
 - Wagner (2021) mean distance from most liked party
 - Wagner (2021)'s average spread of scores
- Problems/Implications Extending it to multiparty systems:
 - Lack of systematic study of implications of measurement / conceptual choices for studying AP in comparative multi-party settings

– We address this gap leveraging a cross-sectional survey experiment fielded in 25 European multiparty democracies

– Focus on:

* Operationalization of partisans:

- how do AP estimates differ between respondents that report to feel attached to a party (explicit partisans) compared to those that neglected such an attachment, yet still reported a vote choice (implicit partisans)?
- how do the distribution of implicit/explicit partisans vary across countries -> cross-national variation imply differential consequences of partisan operationalization for external validity of study, as partisan sample may or may not be representative population of interest

• Study proceeds in three substudies / analyses:

1. Analysis of Thermometer Items (attitudinal, vertical, party-targeted) -> how does measurement and conceptualization influence the resulting estimates of AP?
2. Analysis of Behavioral Consequences (behavioral, horizontal, citizen-targeted conjoint scenario) -> how does measurement and conceptualization influence the behavioral consequences of AP?
3. Analysis of AP Sorting with Muslim attribute -> how does partisan AP interact with other salient group identities? Muslimhood as salient out-group feature in European societies -> conjoint experiment: assumes uniform distribution -> unrealistic but interesting (if “Muslim” feature uniformly distributed, AP asymmetrically affected -> social identity complexity, interactions can be asymmetric) -> use empirical distribution of Muslim partisan respondents -> AP x Muslim estimate in sorted scenario

2 Theory

The central research question is: How do conceptual and measurement choices condition our understanding of AP in multiparty democracies?

We proceed in steps. In our first study

3 Research design

3.1 Data

3.2 Empirical Strategy

4 Results

4.1 Study 1: Operationalizing Attitudinal Affective Polarization in Multiparty Systems

RQ: How do alternative operationalizations of partisanship and thermometer-based indices affect estimates of attitudinal AP?

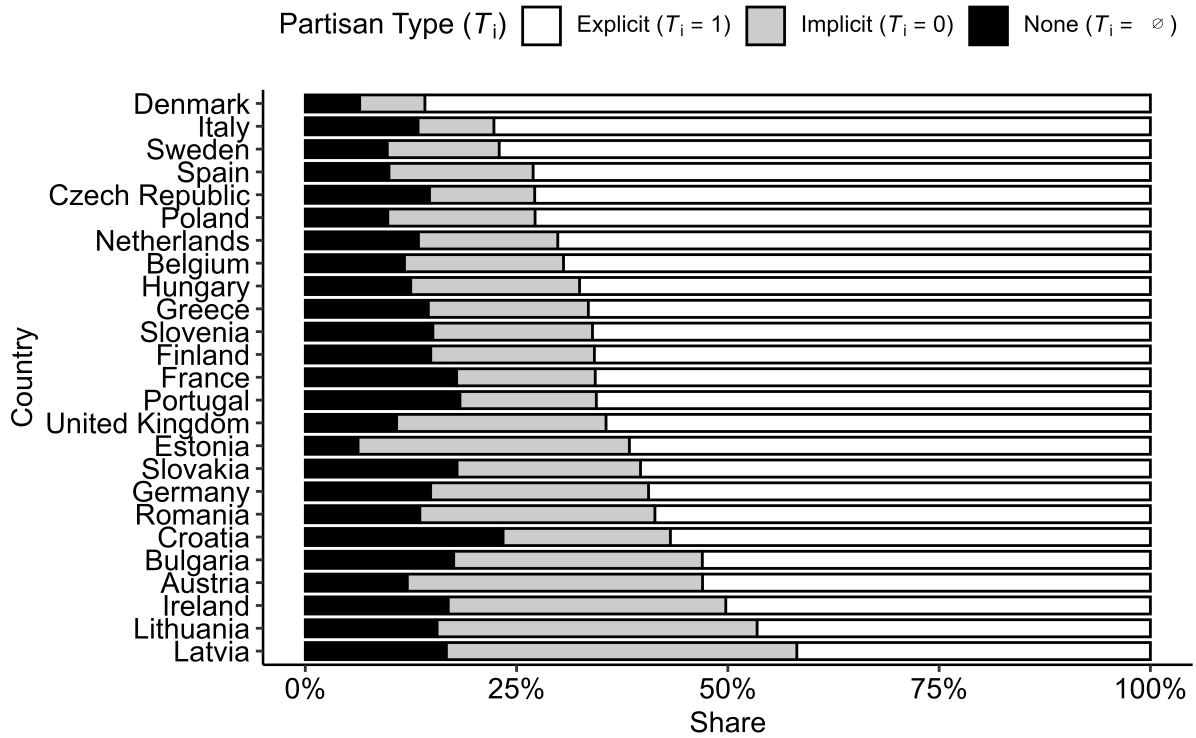


Figure 1: Distribution of partisan types, by country. Stacked horizontal bars show the within-country share (%) of three partisan types: explicit partisans (respondents who reported a subjective attachment to a party, $T_i = 1$), implicit partisans (respondents who reported no attachment but did report a vote preference or intention, $T_i = 0$), and respondents who reported neither (none, $T_i = \emptyset$). Percentages sum to 100% within each country, with country samples containing about 1,100 respondents each (detailed numbers are reported in appendix section X).

Source: [Code Notebook 3.1](#)

-> Distribution of reported attachment (explicit types) or partisan composition varies substantially across countries

-> share of explicit partisans varies from ~85% in Denmark to ~41% in Latvia

-> share of implicit partisans varies from ~41% in Latvia to 8% in Denmark

-> share of non-partisans varies from 23% in Croatia to 6% in Estonia

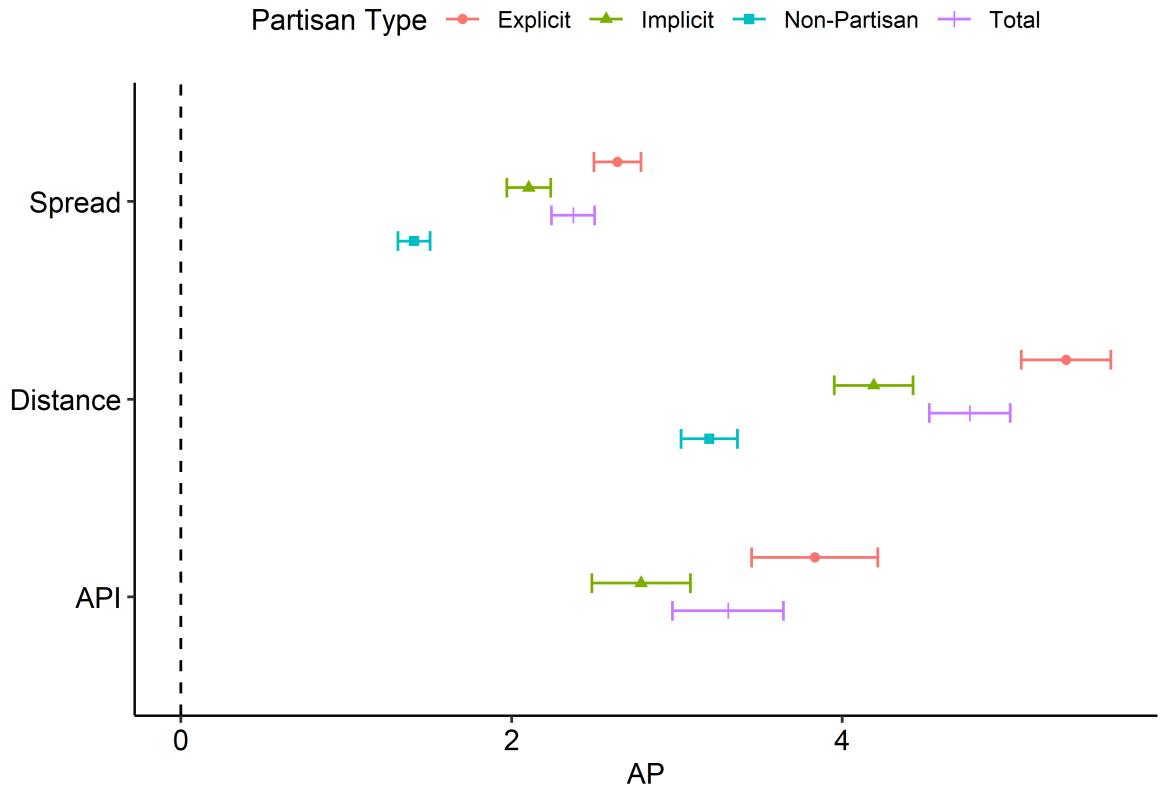


Figure 2: Attitudinal Affective Polarization in the EU25. This figure displays aggregated attitudinal AP scores across three operationalizations, categorized by partisan attachment type. API follows Reiljan (2020)’s and is calculated as the distance between in-group and average out-group feeling thermometer scores. Distance and Spread follow Wagner (2021), capturing the root mean square distance from the most-liked party and the overall standard deviation of party evaluations, respectively. All estimates are weighted by party vote shares within each country to reflect national party system compositions and then averaged across 25 European countries. [OLD: To ensure comparability across measures, thermometer scores (originally 0–100) are rescaled to a 0–10 range]. Explicit partisans are respondents reporting a psychological attachment to a party; Implicit partisans are those denying partisan attachment but reporting a vote choice; Total includes all individuals with a partisan anchor; and Non-Partisans are respondents without a reported party anchor. Error bars indicate 95% confidence intervals based on cross-national variance.

Source: [Code Notebook 3.2](#)

- > across measures, explicit partisans systematically higher AP than implicit
- > Non-partisans (which can be included in Wagner measures) systematically less polarized
- > restricting sample to explicit partisans (identifiers) yields higher aggregate AP

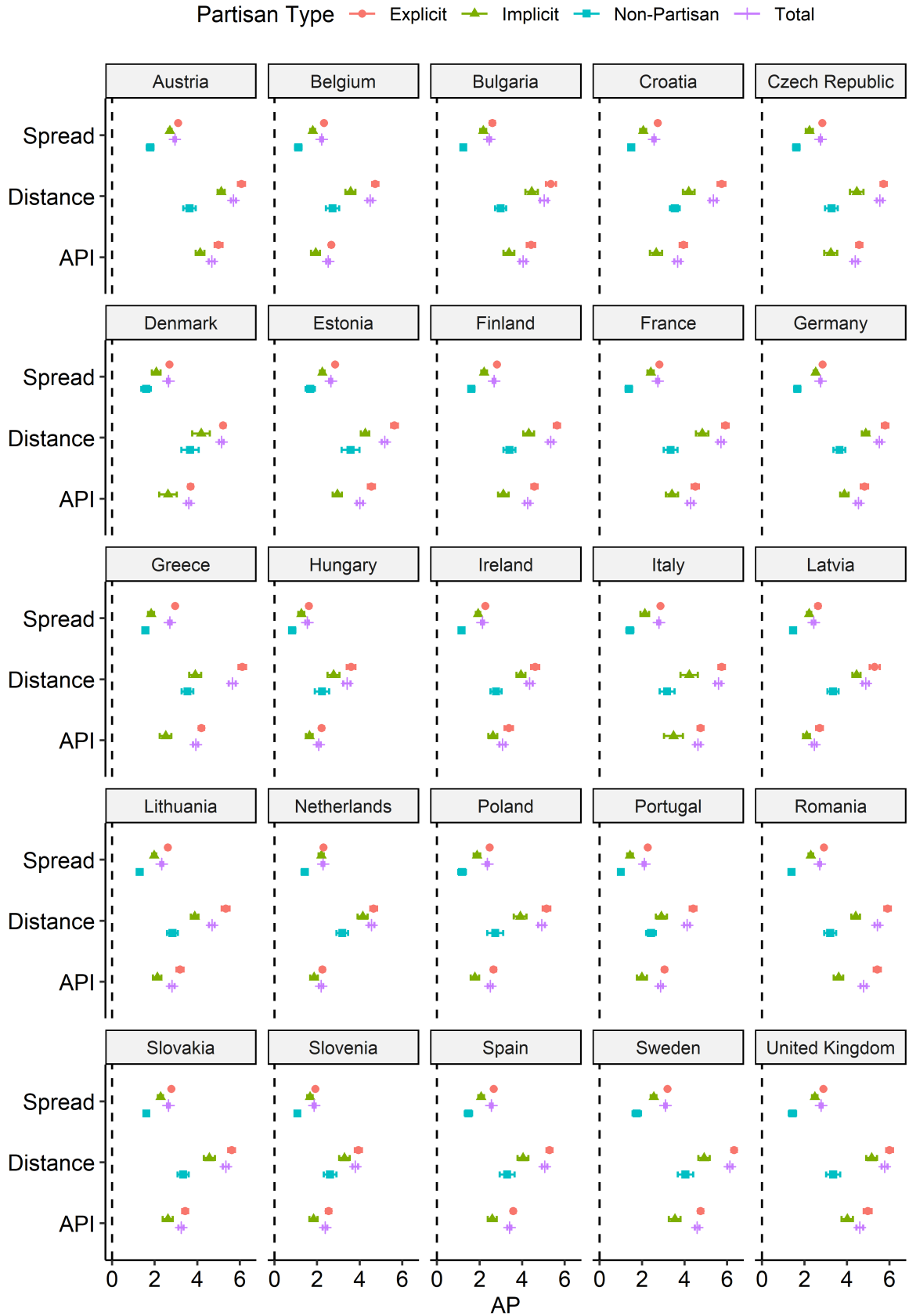


Figure 3: Attitudinal Affective Polarization across European Countries. This figure displays country-specific estimates of attitudinal affective polarization (AP) across three operationalizations and partisan attachment types. Attitudinal API follows Reiljan (2020) and is calculated as the distance between in-group and average out-group feeling thermometer scores. Attitudinal Distance and Spread follow wagner2021affective, capturing the root mean square distance from the most-liked party and the overall standard deviation of party evaluations, respectively. Estimates are calculated separately for each country and weighted by party vote shares to reflect national party system compositions. Thermometer scores (originally 0–100) are rescaled to a 0–10 range to ensure comparability across measures. Explicit partisans are respondents reporting a psychological attachment to a party; Implicit partisans are those denying partisan attachment but reporting a vote choice; Total includes all individuals with a partisan anchor; and Non-

Source: [Code Notebook 3.2](#)

-> pattern roughly consistent across countries (i.e., blue -> green -> orange)

-> cross-national variation in terms of magnitudes and within-country differences

-> With the varying country-specific distributions (Figure 1) in mind, AP estimates for all partisans (total) shift either close to that of explicit partisans (e.g. Denmark, Greece, Sweden) or stay centered between estimates for explicit and implicit partisans (e.g. Austria, Bulgaria, Ireland)

4.2 Study 2: Behavioral Consequences of Affective Polarization

RQ: Do these operational differences alter the observed behavioral consequences of polarization?

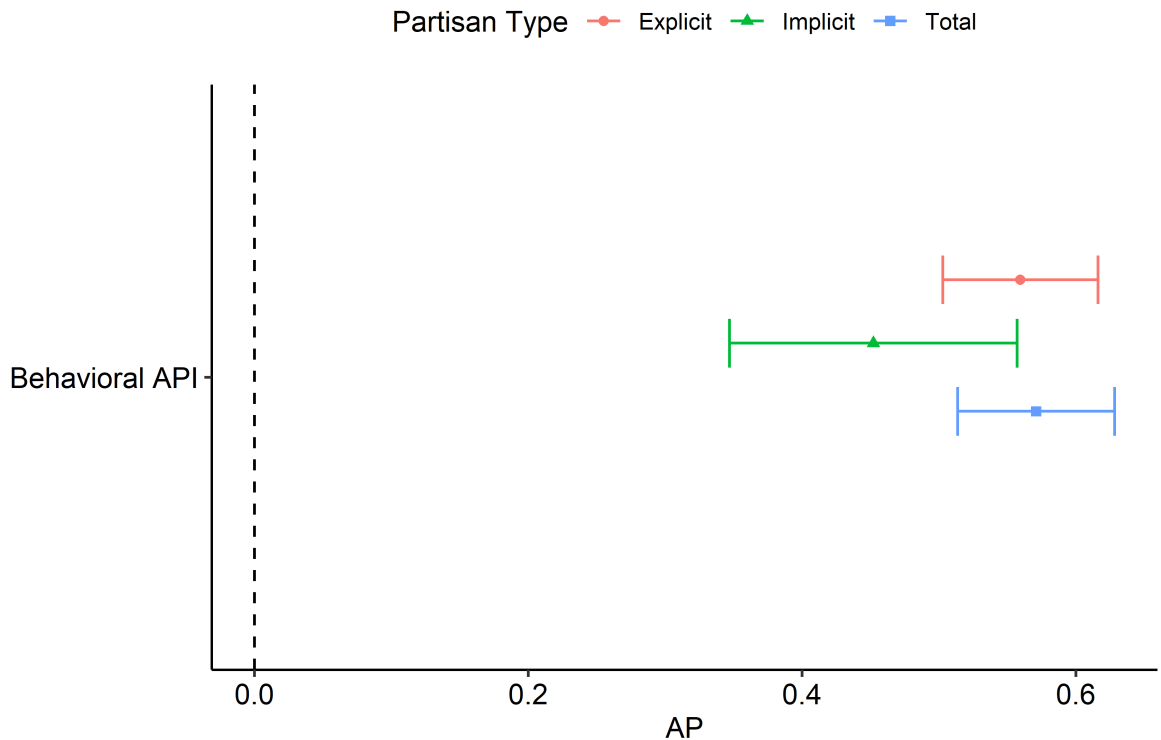


Figure 4: Behavioral Affective Polarization in the EU25. This figure displays aggregated behavioral affective polarization (AP) scores across partisan attachment types. Behavioral API (Token) measures the difference in expected token allocations between co-partisans and out-partisans in a conjoint allocation game. All estimates are weighted by party vote shares within each country to reflect national party system compositions and then averaged across 25 European countries. Explicit partisans are respondents reporting a psychological attachment to a party; Implicit partisans are those denying partisan attachment but reporting a vote choice; Total includes all individuals with a partisan anchor; and Non-Partisans are respondents without a reported party anchor. Error bars indicate 95% confidence intervals based on cross-national variance.

Source: [Code Notebook 3.2](#)

-> unlike in attitudinal AP, intervals for explicit and implicit overlap, hence no systematic difference

-> preliminary interpretation: according to data explicit attachment does not matter for behavioral AP

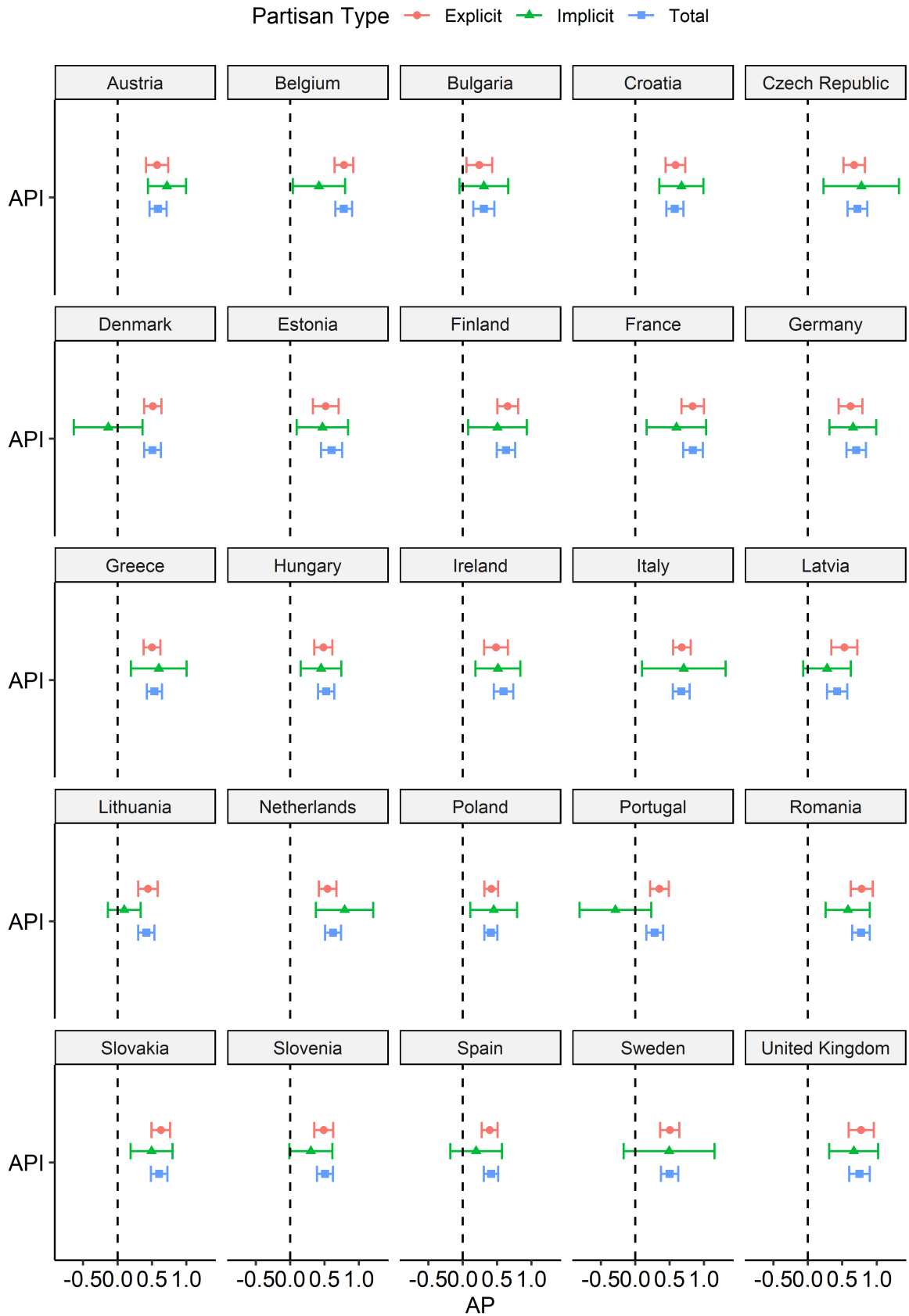


Figure 5: Behavioral Affective Polarization across European Countries. This figure displays country-specific estimates of behavioral affective polarization (AP) across partisan attachment types. Behavioral API (Token) measures the difference in expected token allocations between co-partisans and out-partisans in a conjoint allocation game. Estimates are calculated separately for each country and weighted by party vote shares to reflect national party system compositions. Explicit partisans are respondents reporting a psychological attachment to a party; Implicit partisans are those denying partisan attachment but reporting a vote choice; Total includes all individuals with a partisan anchor; and Non-Partisans are respondents without a reported party anchor. Error bars indicate 95% confidence intervals.

Source: [Code Notebook 3.2](#)

- > pooled results generally consistent across countries
- > no systematic difference in behavioral AP between explicit and implicit
- > “strongest tendency” in Denmark, Lithuania and Portugal
- > otherwise almost no difference
- > estimate for total partisans drawn to explicit partisans (due to conjoint setup)

4.3 Study 3: Partisan Sorting and Muslim Outgroup Salience

How does partisan affective polarization interact with salient outgroup identities – specifically Muslimhood – to structure patterns of political sorting? Are there differences between explicit and implicit partisans?

5 Limitations

- Party-targeted attitudinal measures only

The attitudinal analysis relies exclusively on party-targeted thermometer ratings. It does not include direct citizen-targeted affect measures, limiting conclusions about horizontal affective polarization at the attitudinal level.

- Assumption underlying party-size weighting

Weighting by electoral party size—common in the literature—implicitly assumes that the probability of encountering partisans is proportional to vote share. This may not hold if certain parties (e.g., radical challenger parties) are socially more or less visible than their electoral strength suggests.

- Cross-sectional design (2019)

The data capture a specific pre-pandemic political context and allow inference only about the level (state) of affective polarization at that point in time. The design does not permit conclusions about temporal dynamics or trends.

- External validity of the experimental setting

Although the conjoint experiment approximates horizontal, citizen-level interactions, it remains an artificial setting. In real-world encounters, identities are rarely presented as explicit labels. Instead, they are inferred through cues and cognitive processes. This limits the direct generalizability of experimentally induced identity effects to everyday social interactions.

6 Conclusion

(Preliminary thoughts) In comparative multi-party systems:

- Affective polarization is not a single quantity.
- Its magnitude and cross-national configuration depend on: - measurement instrument (attitudinal/behavioral) - ingroup definition (implicit/explicit/all), - inclusion of non-partisans, - and whether polarization is conceptualized vertically or horizontally.

Rather than asking only “*How polarized are European democracies?*”,
we ask:

How does conceptualization reshape what, and even who, we observe as polarized in multi-party contexts?

7 References

- Hahm, Hyeonho, David Hilpert, and Thomas König. 2024. “Divided We Unite: The Nature of Partyism and the Role of Coalition Partnership in Europe.” *American Political Science Review* 118 (1): 69–87. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0003055423000266>.
- Iyengar, Shanto, Gaurav Sood, and Yphtach Lelkes. 2012. “Affect, Not Ideology: A Social Identity Perspective on Polarization.” *Public Opinion Quarterly* 76 (3): 405–31. <https://doi.org/10.1093/poq/nfs038>.
- Reiljan, Andres. 2020. “‘Fear and Loathing Across Party Lines’(also) in Europe: Affective Polarisation in European Party Systems.” *European Journal of Political Research* 59 (2): 376–96. <https://doi.org/10.1111/1475-6765.12351>.
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8 Appendix

8.1 Sample descriptives

Table 1: Sample composition by country. Numbers denote respondents.

Country	N	Percent
Austria	1277	0.04
Belgium	1305	0.04
Bulgaria	982	0.03
Croatia	1240	0.04
Czech Republic	1135	0.04

Table 1: Sample composition by country. Numbers denote respondents.

Country	N	Percent
Denmark	1200	0.04
Estonia	944	0.03
Finland	1160	0.04
France	1156	0.04
Germany	1188	0.04
Greece	1161	0.04
Hungary	986	0.03
Ireland	1061	0.04
Italy	1172	0.04
Latvia	1148	0.04
Lithuania	1265	0.04
Netherlands	1221	0.04
Poland	1198	0.04
Portugal	1187	0.04
Romania	1480	0.05
Slovakia	1297	0.04
Slovenia	1135	0.04
Spain	1396	0.05
Sweden	1254	0.04
United Kingdom	1279	0.04
Total	29827	0.99

Table 2: Sample composition by country and gender. Numbers denote respondents.

Country	Male	Female	Other
Austria	645	630	2
Belgium	729	574	2
Bulgaria	463	518	1
Croatia	545	694	1
Czech Republic	515	618	2
Denmark	690	508	2
Estonia	331	611	2
Finland	586	567	7
France	562	594	0
Germany	587	597	4
Greece	588	572	1
Hungary	493	492	1
Ireland	481	577	3
Italy	603	569	0
Latvia	415	733	0
Lithuania	462	803	0
Netherlands	642	577	2
Poland	540	658	0
Portugal	593	593	1
Romania	837	641	2
Slovakia	550	746	1
Slovenia	569	566	0

Table 2: Sample composition by country and gender. Numbers denote respondents.

Country	Male	Female	Other
Spain	677	718	1
Sweden	648	602	4
United Kingdom	635	641	3
Total	14386	15399	42

Source: [Code Notebook 3.1](#)

Table 3: Sample composition by country and age group. Numbers denote respondents.

Country	18 to 25	26 to 35	36 to 45	46 to 55	56 to 65	66 to 75	> 75
Austria	144	177	249	263	286	142	0
Belgium	197	132	160	235	333	239	3
Bulgaria	57	195	231	250	212	33	0
Croatia	119	251	272	331	205	47	0
Czech Republic	88	187	227	219	281	126	0
Denmark	132	134	139	208	321	249	4
Estonia	56	168	164	283	265	7	0
Finland	125	178	210	242	259	137	1
France	123	176	242	267	279	51	0
Germany	125	184	200	240	313	117	0
Greece	77	202	376	318	136	34	0
Hungary	51	175	196	166	273	117	1
Ireland	128	216	223	187	169	120	0

Table 3: Sample composition by country and age group. Numbers denote respondents.

Country	18 to 25	26 to 35	36 to 45	46 to 55	56 to 65	66 to 75	> 75
Italy	104	196	264	195	294	98	2
Latvia	78	251	231	338	239	6	0
Lithuania	223	311	257	250	212	2	0
Netherlands	149	126	161	234	340	194	3
Poland	200	342	222	187	196	42	0
Portugal	112	260	289	231	218	67	1
Romania	128	339	373	347	202	65	0
Slovakia	139	223	282	290	250	108	1
Slovenia	97	186	246	284	234	72	0
Spain	125	293	355	305	228	66	1
Sweden	124	165	156	234	297	261	3
United Kingdom	121	184	196	234	268	250	1
Total	3022	5251	5921	6338	6310	2650	21

Source: [Code Notebook 3.1](#)

8.2 Survey item wording (English version)

Table 4: Survey item wording (English version)

Variable	Question
Feeling	We would like to get your feelings toward some political parties and
Thermometer	political leaders in the news these days. Below there is a list of parties and people. I'd like you to rate them using something we call the feeling thermometer. Ratings between 50 degrees and 100 degrees mean that you feel favorable and warm toward the party or person. Ratings between 0 degrees and 50 degrees mean that you don't feel favorable toward the party or person and that you don't care too much for that party or person. You would rate the political party or the person at the 50 degree mark if you don't feel particularly warm or cold toward the person.

8.3 Experimental setup

Before the behavioral games, Hahm, Hilpert, and König (2024) presented respondents a short background information overview and instructions. For the dictator game, these were: *This game is played by pairs of individuals. Each pair is made up of a Player 1 and a Player 2. Each player will have some information about the other player, but you will not be told who the other players are during or after the experiment. The game is conducted as follows: A sum of 10 tokens will be provisionally allocated to Player 1 at the start of each round. Player 1 will then decide how much of the 10 tokens to offer to Player 2. Player 1 could give some, all, or none of the 10 tokens. Player 1 keeps all tokens not given to Player 2. Player 2 gets to keep all the tokens Player 1 offers. You will play this game three times with three different people.* In the trust game, the provided information

and instruction were: *This game is played by pairs of individuals. Each pair is made up of a Player 1 and a Player 2. Each player will have some information about the other player, but you will not be told who the other players are during or after the experiment. Each player will receive 10 tokens. Player 1 then has the opportunity to give a portion of his or her 10 tokens to Player 2. Player 1 could give some, all, or none of the 10 tokens. Whatever amount Player 1 decides to give to Player 2 will be tripled before it is passed on to Player 2. Player 2 then has the option of returning any portion of this tripled amount to Player 1. Then, the game is over. Player 1 receives whatever he or she keeps from the original 10 tokens, plus anything returned to him or her by Player 2. Player 2 receives their original 10 tokens, plus whatever he or she keeps after returning any portion of the tripled amount to Player 1. You will play this game three times, with three different people. The more tokens you obtain, the more successful you will be.*

In both games respondents were shown a tabular overview of Player 2 after the instructions. Figure 6 shows an example of such a profile along with the interface respondents were provided to assign the 10 tokens. Each round, a new profile was displayed to respondents.

	Player 2
Nationality	United Kingdom
Age	18
Party Affiliation	Labour Party (Labour)
Gender	Female
Religion	Muslim
Social Class	Middle Class

So put the number of tokens you wish to keep in the box labeled "Player 1." Put the tokens you wish to go to Player 2 in the box labeled "Player 2."

Player 1 (You)	0	Token(s)
Player 2	0	Token(s)
Total	0	Token(s)

Figure 6: Example of potential co-player profile.

8.4 Distribution of Y

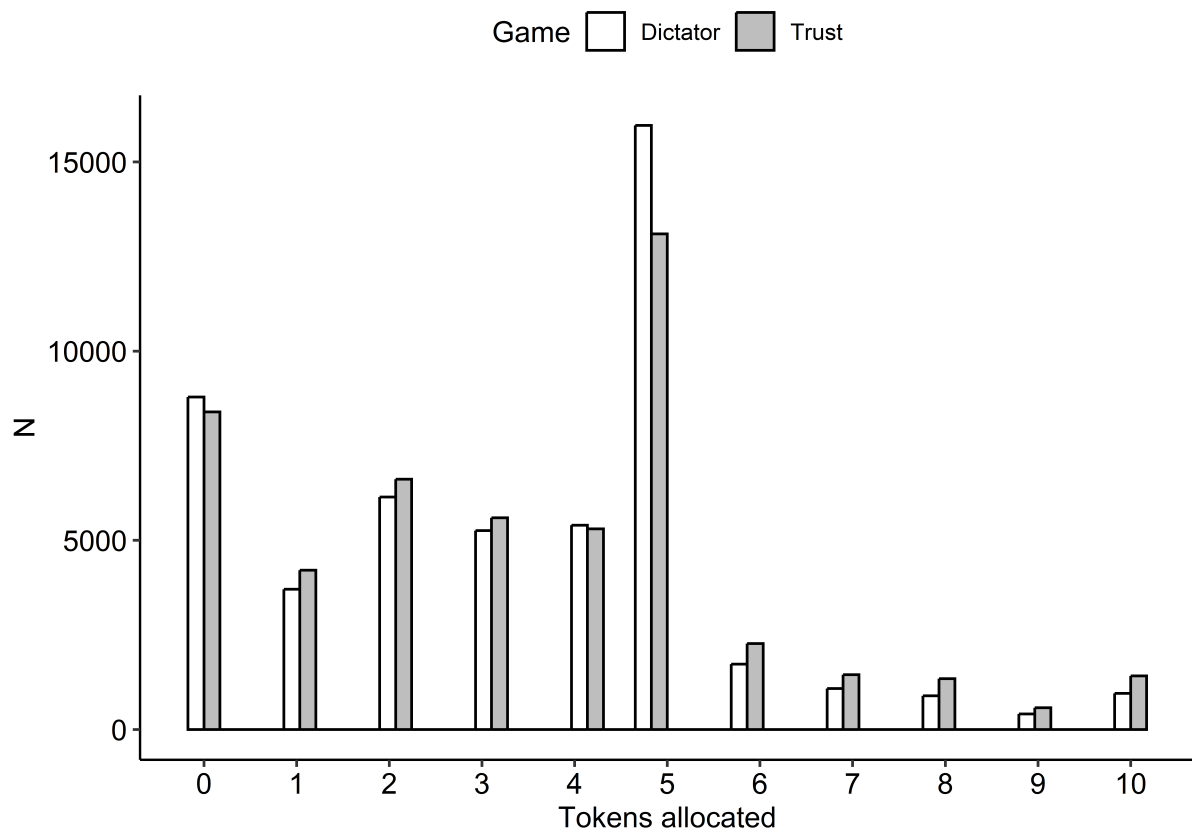


Figure 7: Distribution of token allocation by game. Dictator game: $Mean = 3.41$, $median = 4$, $SD = 2.35$. Trust game: $Mean = 3.48$, $median = 4$, $SD = 2.49$

Source: [Code Notebook 3.1](#)

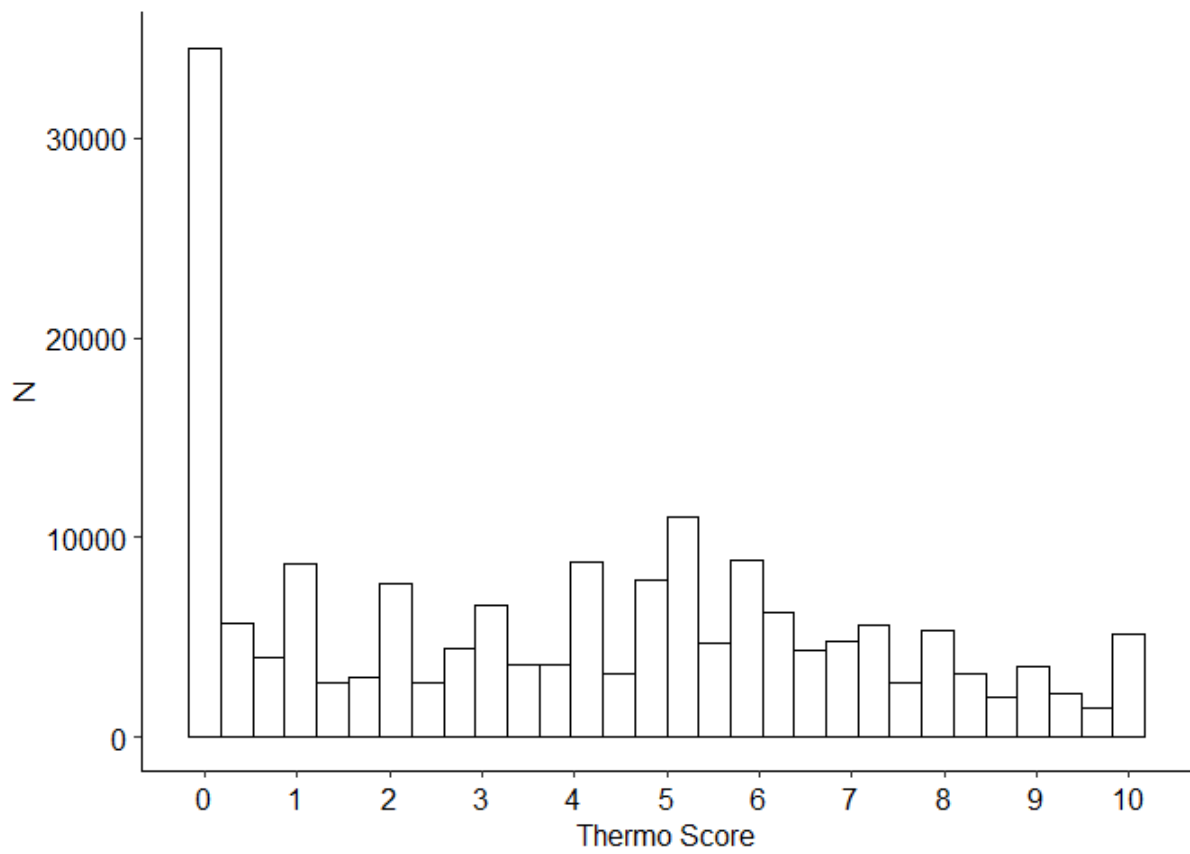


Figure 8: Distribution of thermometer ratings (rescaled from 0-100 to 0-10). $Mean = 3.89$, $median = 4$, $SD = 3.04$

Source: [Code Notebook 3.2](#)

8.5 Robustness